

Pit Log Meat Cuts, Temps & Smoke Field Guide

Two different numbers matter, and confusing them is how people get sick or serve tough brisket. Safety temperature first, texture temperature second. SMOKE. LOG. MASTER.

THREE NUMBERS. NEVER THE SAME NUMBER.

1. Safety minimum	The food safety floor, set by USDA FSIS. Never go under it. It is not a preference.
2. Culinary preference	How you like a steak or a fillet. Rare and medium-rare sit BELOW the minimum. This guide says so every time.
3. Tenderness target	Where brisket and shoulder turn tender. Always above the minimum. A checkpoint, not a guarantee.

1. SAFE MINIMUM INTERNAL TEMPERATURE

These are food safety minimums from USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service. They are not preferences. Measure with a probe in the thickest part, away from bone and fat, before the food leaves the heat.

Food	Minimum	Notes
Poultry, all of it	165 F / 74 C	Whole birds, pieces, ground poultry and stuffing. No rest required.
Ground meats	160 F / 71 C	Beef, pork, veal, lamb, goat once ground. Organ meats too.
Beef, pork, veal, lamb, goat: steaks, chops, roasts	145 F / 63 C	PLUS a 3 minute rest before carving. Pork can still be pink at 145 F and be safe.
Fresh or smoked ham, uncooked	145 F / 63 C	Plus a 3 minute rest.
Fully cooked ham, reheating	165 F / 74 C	140 F only if it was packaged at a USDA-inspected plant.
Fish and shellfish	145 F / 63 C	Or until the flesh is opaque and separates easily with a fork (FDA).
Egg dishes	160 F / 71 C	Smoked egg dishes and casseroles follow the same figure.
Leftovers and casseroles	165 F / 74 C	Refrigerate smoked meat within 2 hours of removing it from the smoker; use within 4 days or freeze (FSIS).

Source: USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service, Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart, page updated 2025-04-14, read 2026-09-02. Colour is not doneness. A cooked burger can stay pink and an undercooked one can look brown; only a thermometer tells you.

Pit Log Field Guide

Handling rules. What the thermometer cannot tell you.

HANDLING, FROM USDA FSIS

The danger zone	Bacteria grow fastest between 40 F and 140 F, doubling in as little as 20 minutes. Never leave food out of refrigeration more than 2 hours, or 1 hour when the air is above 90 F. Hold hot food at or above 140 F and cold food at or below 40 F.
Two thermometers	Smoke with two thermometers: one for the air in the smoker, one for the food. Keep the smoker air between 225 and 300 F throughout the cook. Use a food thermometer to decide when the meat is done, never the clock.
Where the probe goes	Insert the thermometer into the thickest part of the food, not touching bone, fat or gristle. For thin foods insert through the side. Check large or irregular pieces in several places. For a whole bird check the innermost thigh and wing and the thickest part of the breast.
Colour is not doneness	Appearance and colour are not reliable indicators of safety or doneness. A burger can be brown and unsafe or pink and safe. Pork at 145 F can be pink. Smoked chicken can stay pink at the bone at 165 F.
The 3 minute rest is part of the 145 F rule	For whole-muscle beef, pork, lamb, goat and veal the safety rule is 145 F AND a rest of at least 3 minutes before carving or eating. The rest is not optional and it is not the same thing as the long barbecue rest.
Never partially cook to finish later	Never brown or partially cook meat or poultry, refrigerate it, and finish later. Bacteria present would not have been destroyed. Partially cooking immediately before transferring to a hot grill is fine.
Thaw and marinate in the refrigerator	Thaw in the refrigerator, in cold water changed every 30 minutes, or in the microwave; never on the counter. Thaw before smoking. Marinate in the refrigerator (beef, pork and lamb up to 5 days; cubes 2 days). Boil used marinade before brushing it on cooked meat, or discard it. Do not cook frozen meat in a slow cooker.
Sauce in the last 15 to 30 minutes	If using a sauce, apply it during the last 15 to 30 minutes of smoking to prevent excess browning or burning.
Chill within 2 hours of leaving the smoker	Refrigerate meat and poultry within 2 hours of removing it from a smoker. Cut into smaller portions, use shallow covered containers, use within 4 days or freeze. Reheat leftovers to 165 F.

PLANNING, NOT DONENESS

Time is planning guidance, never doneness	Smoking can take 4 to 8 hours or more; time depends on the cut, its size and shape, distance from heat, coal temperature and weather. A common planning estimate for large barbecue cuts is about one hour per pound of raw weight at 200 to 250 F. Every published time on a Pit Log surface is a planning estimate and must be labelled approximate.
Pit temperature bands	Low and slow for collagen cuts (brisket, pork butt) means 200 to 250 F pit air so the outside does not overcook while the centre catches up (Texas A&M). FSIS's food-safety band for a smoker is 225 to 300 F. Poultry skin crisps better at the top of the band or above it.

Pit Log Field Guide

Beef. Meat from full-grown cattle about two years old. The tough, hard-working primals (chuck, brisket, round, shank) want low and slow; the middle meats (rib, short loin, sirloin) want dry heat.

BEEF: USDA SAFE MINIMUM 145 F / 63 C

Cook all raw beef, pork, lamb, goat and veal steaks, chops and roasts to a minimum internal temperature of 145 F (62.8 C) and allow to rest for at least 3 minutes. This is the floor for every beef cut below.

BEEF PRIMAL REGIONS

Region	Tender/Rich	Best method	Finish	Slice
1. Chuck	2 / 4	smoke, braise	200-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Across the grain
2. Rib	5 / 5	grill, reverse sear	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain
3. Short loin	5 / 3	grill, sear	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain
4. Sirloin	4 / 3	grill, roast	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain; on tri-tip, find the two grain directions and cut each half separately
5. Brisket	1 / 5	smoke	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Slice the flat and the point across their own grain; the two muscles run in different directions
6. Plate	2 / 5	smoke (short ribs), grill hot and fast (skirt, hanger)	200-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Skirt: thin, across the grain, at an angle
7. Flank	2 / 3	grill, sear	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Thin, across the grain, on a bias
8. Round	2 / 2	roast, braise	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Thin, across the grain
9. Shank	1 / 4	braise, smoke then braise	200-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Usually served on the bone or pulled

Doneness (steaks and roasts, final temperature after rest, industry scale): Medium rare 145 F; Medium 160 F; Well done 170 F.

Rare, medium-rare and medium figures are a preference, not a food safety standard. They fall below the USDA minimum. Where the two differ, the USDA minimum governs. See pitlog.app/temperatures for the full scales.

WOODS, AND THE MISTAKES

Woods: Oak, Hickory, Mesquite, Pecan, Cherry.

- ☐ Chuck: Pulling a chuck roast at 165 F because the safety minimum is met; it is safe but tough.
- ☐ Rib: Cooking a ribeye to a tenderness window; it is not a collagen cut.
- ☐ Short loin: Treating short loin as a low-and-slow cut.
- ☐ Sirloin: Slicing tri-tip in one direction end to end.
- ☐ Brisket: Cooking to a number instead of probe feel.
- ☐ Plate: Cooking skirt past medium; it turns to rope.

Pit Log Field Guide

Pork. Pork is classed as red meat. Since 2011 USDA's whole-muscle minimum is 145 F with a 3 minute rest, and safely cooked pork can still be pink. The shoulder is the most forgiving barbecue cut there is.

PORK: USDA SAFE MINIMUM 145 F / 63 C

Cook all raw beef, pork, lamb, goat and veal steaks, chops and roasts to a minimum internal temperature of 145 F (62.8 C) and allow to rest for at least 3 minutes. This is the floor for every pork cut below.

PORK PRIMAL REGIONS

Region	Tender/Rich	Best method	Finish	Slice
1. Butt (Boston butt)	2 / 4	smoke, braise	195-205 F, bone slip (craft)	Pull, do not slice, once at the tenderness window
2. Loin	4 / 2	grill, roast	190-203 F, bend test (craft)	Across the grain for chops and roasts
3. Ham (leg)	3 / 2	roast, smoke	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain, off the bone
4. Picnic shoulder	2 / 3	smoke, braise	195-205 F, bone slip (craft)	Pull
5. Spareribs	2 / 4	smoke	190-203 F, bend test (craft)	Between the bones, meat side down so you can see them
6. Belly	3 / 5	smoke, cure (bacon)	190-200 F, fork tender (craft)	Across the slab into thick slices, or cubes for burnt ends
7. Hock	1 / 4	simmer, braise	195-205 F, bone slip (craft)	Pulled off the bone

Doneness (chops, loin, tenderloin and whole-muscle roasts, industry scale): Medium (USDA minimum) 145 F; Medium well 150-155 F; Well done 160 F.

WOODS, AND THE MISTAKES

Woods: Hickory, Apple, Cherry, Pecan.

- ☐ Butt (Boston butt): Panicking at the stall and cranking the pit.
- ☐ Loin: Cooking loin or tenderloin to 160 F out of old habit; the minimum has been 145 F since 2011.
- ☐ Ham (leg): Reheating any ham to 140 F because a graphic said so; that figure is only for USDA-inspected-plant packaged ham.
- ☐ Picnic shoulder: Leaving thick skin on and expecting bark.
- ☐ Spareribs: Following 3-2-1 by the clock on a thin rack and steaming it to mush.
- ☐ Belly: Skin-on belly in a smoker; the skin never crisps at 250 F. Remove it or score deeply.

Pit Log Field Guide

Lamb. Lamb is a sheep under about a year old; older animals are mutton. Rack and loin are tender dry-heat cuts. Shoulder, shank and breast are collagen cuts that reward low and slow.

LAMB: USDA SAFE MINIMUM 145 F / 63 C

Cook all raw beef, pork, lamb, goat and veal steaks, chops and roasts to a minimum internal temperature of 145 F (62.8 C) and allow to rest for at least 3 minutes. This is the floor for every lamb cut below.

LAMB PRIMAL REGIONS

Region	Tender/Rich	Best method	Finish	Slice
1. Shoulder	2 / 4	smoke, braise	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Against the grain (Lamb Board rule for all lamb); pull when at the tenderness window
2. Rack	5 / 4	roast, grill	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Between the bones, against the grain
3. Loin	5 / 3	grill, sear	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain for a roast; chops are served whole
4. Leg	3 / 2	roast, grill (butterflied)	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Against the grain, parallel to the bone on a bone-in leg (Lamb Board: carve against the grain for the best texture)
5. Breast	2 / 5	smoke, braise	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Between the bones
6. Flank	2 / 3	grill, sear	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Thin, across the grain
7. Shank	1 / 3	braise, smoke then braise	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	On the bone

Doneness (chops, rack, leg and roasts. Pull temperature and final temperature after rest, industry scale): Medium rare 145 F; Medium 160 F; Well 170 F.

Rare, medium-rare and medium figures are a preference, not a food safety standard. They fall below the USDA minimum. Where the two differ, the USDA minimum governs. See pitlog.app/temperatures for the full scales.

WOODS, AND THE MISTAKES

Woods: Oak, Pecan, Hickory, Cherry.

- ☐ Shoulder: Overpowering it with mesquite.
- ☐ Rack: Cooking a rack to a shoulder temperature.
- ☐ Loin: Overcooking; there is no fat to hide behind.
- ☐ Leg: Cooking a lean leg to well done and wondering why it is dry.
- ☐ Breast: Pulling ribs early; unrendered lamb fat is unpleasant.
- ☐ Flank: Slicing with the grain.

Pit Log Field Guide

Goat. Goat is red meat, very lean, and cut like lamb. FSIS notes a goat carcass rarely has enough fat to protect it from drying, which is why gentle heat and moisture matter more than with any other animal here.

GOAT: USDA SAFE MINIMUM 145 F / 63 C

Cook all raw beef, pork, lamb, goat and veal steaks, chops and roasts to a minimum internal temperature of 145 F (62.8 C) and allow to rest for at least 3 minutes. This is the floor for every goat cut below.

GOAT PRIMAL REGIONS

Region	Tender/Rich	Best method	Finish	Slice
1. Shoulder	2 / 3	smoke then wrap, braise	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Pull
2. Rack	5 / 3	grill, roast	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Between the bones
3. Loin	5 / 2	grill, sear	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain
4. Leg	3 / 2	roast, smoke	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Against the grain
5. Breast	2 / 3	braise, smoke then wrap	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Between the bones
6. Flank	2 / 2	grill, grind	145 F USDA minimum + 3 min rest; doneness is your call above it	Thin, across the grain
7. Shank	1 / 3	braise, smoke then braise	195-205 F, probe tender (craft)	On the bone

Doneness (chops, rack, leg and roasts. Pull temperature and final temperature after rest, industry scale): Medium rare 145 F; Medium 160 F; Well 170 F.

Rare, medium-rare and medium figures are a preference, not a food safety standard. They fall below the USDA minimum. Where the two differ, the USDA minimum governs. See pitlog.app/temperatures for the full scales.

WOODS, AND THE MISTAKES

Woods: Oak, Pecan, Mesquite.

- ☐ Shoulder: Running the pit hot; FSIS: goat dries easily.
- ☐ Rack: Overcooking a lean rack.
- ☐ Loin: Overcooking.
- ☐ Leg: Treating an older animal's leg as a roast.
- ☐ Breast: Dry, unwrapped cook to the end.
- ☐ Flank: Slicing with the grain.

Pit Log Field Guide

Chicken. Every part of a chicken, including ground chicken and stuffing, is safe at 165 F, checked in the innermost thigh and wing and the thickest breast. No rest is required by USDA. Pink meat near the bone can persist at 165 F, especially on smoked young birds, and is not a sign of danger.

CHICKEN: USDA SAFE MINIMUM 165 F / 74 C

Cook all poultry, including ground poultry, giblets and stuffing, to 165 F (73.9 C). This is the floor for every chicken cut below.

CHICKEN PRIMAL REGIONS

Region	Tender/Rich	Best method	Finish	Slice
1. Breast	3 / 1	grill, smoke at high pit temp	165 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Across the grain for slices
2. Wing	4 / 4	smoke then crisp, grill	165 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Split at the joints
3. Thigh	4 / 4	smoke, grill	190-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Served whole or pulled
4. Drumstick	3 / 3	smoke, grill	190-205 F, probe tender (craft)	Served whole
5. Back	2 / 3	simmer (stock), roast	165 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Joint the bird; slice the breast across the grain
6. Tail	3 / 5	smoke (on the bird), simmer	165 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Not applicable

WOODS, AND THE MISTAKES

Woods: Apple, Cherry, Pecan, Maple.

- ☐ Breast: Pulling at 160 F to 'let carryover finish it'. The safety rule is a 165 F reading; carryover is not a safety mechanism.
- ☐ Wing: Low and slow to the end; rubbery skin.
- ☐ Thigh: Pulling at 165 F when you wanted rendered dark meat; it is safe but chewy at the joint.
- ☐ Drumstick: Probe touching bone reads high and fools you into pulling early.
- ☐ Back: Stuffing a bird ahead of time (FSIS: stuff immediately before cooking, and the stuffing must also reach 165 F).

Pit Log Field Guide

Salmon. USDA FSIS and FDA both put fish at 145 F, or until the flesh is opaque and separates easily with a fork. Salmon cooks fast, does not stall, and is the one Pit Log animal where the delicate flavour argues for the mildest woods.

SALMON: USDA SAFE MINIMUM 145 F / 63 C

Cook fish and shellfish to 145 F (62.8 C), or until the flesh is opaque and separates easily with a fork. This is the floor for every salmon cut below.

SALMON PRIMAL REGIONS

Region	Tender/Rich	Best method	Finish	Slice
1. Collar	4 / 5	grill, smoke	145 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Served whole; flake off the bone
2. Top loin (back)	4 / 3	grill, sear	145 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Portion across the fillet
3. Center cut	4 / 4	grill, bake	145 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Portion across the fillet; serve skin-side down
4. Belly	5 / 5	smoke, grill	145 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Strips or bite-size pieces
5. Tail	3 / 2	bake, poach	145 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Portion across
6. Second cut (tail meat)	3 / 3	smoke, simmer (chowder)	145 F USDA minimum; doneness is your call above it	Flaked

Rare, medium-rare and medium figures are a preference, not a food safety standard. They fall below the USDA minimum. Where the two differ, the USDA minimum governs. See pitlog.app/temperatures for the full scales.

WOODS, AND THE MISTAKES

Woods: Alder, Apple, Cherry.

- ☐ Collar: Throwing it away with the head.
- ☐ Top loin (back): Overcooking a lean portion; check early.
- ☐ Center cut: Skin off in the smoker; it dries and sticks.
- ☐ Belly: Same timing as a thick loin; it is done long before.
- ☐ Tail: Smoking a tail portion as long as a center cut.
- ☐ Second cut (tail meat): Serving it as a centre-of-plate fillet.

Pit Log Field Guide

Smoke wood pairing. Match the smoke to the meat and the length of the cook.

THE EIGHT WOODS

Wood	Strength	Character	Best with
Oak	medium	Balanced, clean, dependable. The all-purpose smoke and the Central Texas standard (post oak).	beef, lamb, goat, pork
Hickory	strong	Bold, savoury, bacon-like. The classic pork and rib smoke; heavy-handed on poultry.	pork, beef
Mesquite	strong	Intense, earthy, fast-burning. Best for hot-and-fast beef; turns harsh over a long cook.	beef, goat
Pecan	medium	Nutty, warm, slightly sweet. A softer relative of hickory.	pork, chicken, beef, lamb
Apple	mild	Sweet, fruity, gentle. Builds slowly; forgiving on poultry and pork.	pork, chicken, salmon
Cherry	mild	Fruity, mild, and it colours the meat a deep mahogany. Pairs with almost everything.	pork, chicken, beef, salmon
Maple	mild	Soft, sweet, subtle. Good with pork, poultry, ham and vegetables.	pork, chicken
Alder	mild	Delicate, clean, faintly sweet. The Pacific Northwest salmon wood.	salmon, chicken

BEST MATCHES BY MEAT

Beef	Oak, Hickory, Mesquite, Pecan, Cherry
Pork	Hickory, Apple, Cherry, Pecan
Lamb	Oak, Pecan, Hickory, Cherry
Goat	Oak, Pecan, Mesquite
Chicken	Apple, Cherry, Pecan, Maple
Salmon	Alder, Apple, Cherry

Burn only wood sold for cooking. No treated, painted or glued wood and no softwood scrap. Never smoke in a galvanized can. Keep the smoker air between 225 and 300 F (USDA FSIS) and use a second thermometer for the meat.

Pit Log Field Guide

2. Texture temperature, which is a preference. Pitmaster convention, not a food safety standard.

TENDERNESS TARGETS FOR THE TOUGH CUTS

Barbecue pulls tough cuts well past the safety minimum on purpose, because collagen needs time and heat to become gelatine. These are pitmaster convention, not a food safety standard, and the finish is judged by feel more than by number. Where an industry body publishes a figure we show it, even when it disagrees with the backyard number.

Cut	Pit temp	Rough time	Finish by
Brisket, packer	225-250 F	roughly 1 to 1.5 hours per pound at 225 to 250 F; 10 to 16 hours for a whole packer	195-205 F, probe tender. Rest 1 to 2 hours wrapped, held above 140 f.
Beef chuck, short ribs, shank	250-275 F	chuck roast roughly 1.5 hours per pound; plate short ribs 6 to 8 hours at 250 to 275 F	200-205 F, probe tender. Rest 30 to 60 minutes.
Pork shoulder / Boston butt	225-275 F	National Pork Board: about 1 hour 15 minutes per pound	195-205 F, bone slip. Rest 1 hour minimum wrapped, held above 140 f, before pulling.
Pork ribs, all cuts	225-250 F	National Pork Board: loin back ribs 3 to 5 hours; St	190-203 F, bend test. Rest 10 to 15 minutes.
Pork belly, burnt ends	225-250 F	National Pork Board: 4 hours in smoke, wrap, about 3 more hours	190-200 F, fork tender. Rest 15 to 30 minutes for a slab; burnt ends are served from the pan.
Lamb or goat shoulder, shank	225-275 F	roughly 1.5 hours per pound at 250 F for a bone-in shoulder	195-205 F, probe tender. Rest 30 to 60 minutes.
Chicken dark meat, pulled	275-325 F	thighs 1.5 to 2 hours at 275 F	190-205 F, probe tender. Rest 5 to 10 minutes.

THE STALL

The stall is the plateau around 150 to 170 F where a large cut's internal temperature stops climbing for hours. The accepted explanation is evaporative cooling from the meat surface balancing the heat from the pit. Wrapping (the Texas crutch) stops the evaporation; waiting keeps the bark firmer.

Times assume a steady pit and are a planning estimate only. Cook to temperature and feel, never to the clock. Start earlier than you think; a cooler holds a finished brisket for hours above 140 F, but nothing rescues one that is not done at dinner time.

Pit Log Field Guide

Pit Log house recipes. Each one prints the USDA minimum and the pitmaster finish side by side.

FROM THE TEST KITCHEN

None of these is called official until it has been cooked and logged. The full recipe, with quantities and every step, is on the page named under each.

Pit Log Central Texas Brisket	Salt, coarse black pepper, post oak, patience. A whole packer smoked at 250 F, wrapped in butcher paper through the stall, pulled probe tender, and rested long above 140 F. Yield: A 12 lb packer feeds 12 to 16. 10 to 16 hours at 250 F, plus a 1 to 2 hour rest. Estimate. Start earlier than you think. -> pitlog.app/recipes/pit-log-central-texas-brisket
Santa Maria-Inspired Tri-Tip	Garlic, salt, pepper and red oak. Smoked to just under the target, seared, rested, and sliced across both grain directions. Yield: A 2.5 lb tri-tip serves 4 to 6. 60 to 90 minutes at 225 F, then a 2 to 3 minute sear per side, plus a 10 minute rest. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/santa-maria-tri-tip
Pit Log Ember Citrus BBQ Sauce	A bright, smoky house sauce built on ketchup, reduced apple juice, fresh orange juice, brown sugar, vinegar, molasses and warm spice. Made for brisket, short ribs and grilled beef. Yield: About 3 cups. Simmer 25 to 30 minutes. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/pit-log-ember-citrus-bbq-sauce
Pit Log Carolina Gold Mustard Sauce	A tangy South Carolina mustard sauce: yellow mustard, apple cider vinegar, brown sugar, honey, Worcestershire, garlic and black pepper. For pulled pork, ribs and chops. Yield: About 2 cups. Simmer 10 to 15 minutes. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/pit-log-carolina-gold-mustard-sauce
Pit Log Honey Garlic Chicken Thighs	Sweet, savoury, smoky. Chicken thighs, honey, soy sauce, garlic, brown sugar, apple cider vinegar and paprika. Glaze goes on in the last 15 to 30 minutes (FSIS). Yield: Serves 4 (8 thighs). 1.5 to 2 hours at 275 F, then a short hot finish. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/pit-log-honey-garlic-chicken-thighs
Mediterranean Lamb Shoulder	Herb-marinated, smoked low and slow until fall-apart tender. Olive oil, garlic, lemon, rosemary, thyme, oregano, sea salt and black pepper. Yield: A 5 to 6 lb bone-in shoulder serves 6 to 8. 6 to 8 hours at 250 F, wrapped for the last half, plus a 30 to 60 minute rest. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/mediterranean-lamb-shoulder
Moroccan Spiced Goat Shoulder	Bold, aromatic, fall-apart tender. Harissa, cumin, coriander, garlic, lemon, olive oil, paprika and cinnamon. Smoke, then wrap or braise, because goat is lean (FSIS). Yield: A 4 to 5 lb bone-in shoulder serves 5 to 6. 5 to 7 hours at 240 F, wrapped with liquid for the second half, plus a 30 minute rest. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/moroccan-spiced-goat-shoulder
Pit Log Maple Cedar Salmon	Sweet, smoky, balanced, on a soaked cedar plank. Maple syrup, Dijon mustard, soy sauce, garlic, lemon juice and smoked paprika. The page prints 145 F as the federal minimum and labels anything lower as preference. Yield: Serves 4. 15 to 20 minutes on a plank at 350 F, or 45 to 60 minutes smoked at 225 F. Estimate. -> pitlog.app/recipes/pit-log-maple-cedar-salmon

Pit Log Field Guide

Sources and method. Every figure in this guide renders from a record, and every record points at a source with the date it was read.

WHERE THE NUMBERS COME FROM

One fact, one record, many surfaces. This PDF, pitlog.app and the Pit Master Log app all render from the same records. Safety figures are quoted from USDA FSIS and FDA. Cut names and doneness scales come from the Beef Checkoff, the National Pork Board and the American Lamb Board. Barbecue mechanics come from Texas A&M Meat Science. Tenderness windows are barbecue convention and are labelled (craft) wherever they appear.

Organisation	Title	Tier	Page updated	Read
U.S. Food and Drug Administration	Selecting and Serving Fresh and Frozen Seafood Safely	tier 1	2024-03-05	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart	tier 1	2025-04-14	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Beef From Farm to Table	tier 1	2024-12-04	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Fresh Pork From Farm to Table	tier 1	2024-12-10	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Lamb From Farm to Table	tier 1	n/a	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Chicken from Farm to Table	tier 1	2024-09-30	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Goat From Farm to Table	tier 1	2024-12-11	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Smoking Meat and Poultry	tier 1	2024-08-13	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Doneness Versus Safety	tier 1	2024-07-10	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Food Thermometers	tier 1	2025-03-21	2026-09-02
USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service	Danger Zone (40 F - 140 F)	tier 1	2023-06-28	2026-09-02
Texas A&M University, Department of Animal Science, Meat Science Section	Texas Barbecue: How to Cook and Smoke Barbecue	tier 2	n/a	2026-09-02
Texas A&M University, Department of Animal Science, Meat Science Section	Texas Barbecue: Barbecue Science	tier 2	n/a	2026-09-02
Texas A&M University, Department of Animal Science, Meat Science Section	Texas Barbecue: Meat Selection for Barbecuing	tier 2	n/a	2026-09-02
American Lamb Board	Learn About the Different Cuts of Lamb	tier 3	n/a	2026-09-02
American Lamb Board	Lamb Cooking Time & Temperature (PDF)	tier 3	n/a	2026-09-02
Cattlemen's Beef Board and National Cattlemen's Beef Association (Beef Checkoff)	Beef. It's What's For Dinner: Cuts and primal pages	tier 3	n/a	2026-09-02
Cattlemen's Beef Board and National Cattlemen's Beef Association (Beef Checkoff)	Determining Doneness	tier 3	n/a	2026-09-02
National Pork Board (Pork Checkoff)	Pork Cuts	tier 3	n/a	2026-09-02
National Pork Board (Pork Checkoff)	Smoking Pork	tier 3	n/a	2026-09-02
AmazingRibs.com (Meathead), reporting experiments by Prof. Greg Blonder, Boston University	What Causes The BBQ Stall: It's Not What You Think	tier 5	2026-07-20	2026-09-02

Tier 1 federal agency; tier 2 university; tier 3 industry body; tier 5 practitioner report, qualitative only. Full list with links: pitlog.app/sources. No Amazon or affiliate link appears in this guide.

Pit Log Field Guide

Cook log. The reference helps once. The log helps you repeat what worked.

COOK LOG, PAGE 1

Pit Log Field Guide

Cook log. The reference helps once. The log helps you repeat what worked.

COOK LOG, PAGE 2

Pit Log Field Guide

Keep the log going.

INTERACTIVE GUIDES

pitlog.app/cuts/beef	Tap a primal, get the cut, the temps, the wood, the recipe.
pitlog.app/temperatures	The full USDA chart, every doneness scale, every source with its date.
pitlog.app/woods	Eight woods, blends, and the pairing matrix.
pitlog.app/recipes	The house recipes, with a printable card and a shopping checklist.

PIT MASTER LOG, THE APP

Log the cook: cut, weight, pit temp, wood, wrap, final temp, rest, result. Compare cooks. Repeat the good ones. Free to start on iPhone and Android; details at pitlog.app.

THE BOOK

Pit Log: The BBQ Cuts, Temps & Smoking Field Guide, the expanded print edition of this guide, is in production. It is built from the same records as this PDF and the website.